

Consonance and dissonance

Consonance is a combination of notes that sound harmonious and pleasing, while dissonance evokes a feeling of tension. The more dissonant the intervals, the greater the tension in the harmony.

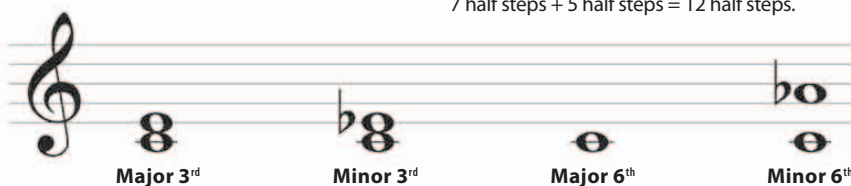
Why is an interval consonant or dissonant?

Different musical cultures have their own ideas of what a stable interval is, and what makes a dissonant clash. Western ideas about harmony, outlined here, derive from the works of the ancient Greek scientist Pythagoras, who calculated the relationship between sounds of different pitches.



92 $\triangle$ Perfect consonances

The most perfect and consonant interval is the octave. When a perfect 4th and a perfect 5th are added, we get an octave: 7 half steps + 5 half steps = 12 half steps.



93 $\triangle$ Imperfect consonances

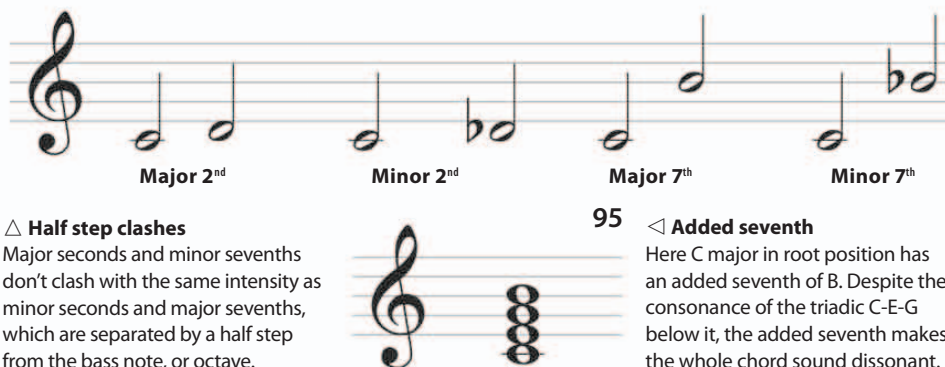
Thirds and sixths are not "true" consonances like fourths and fifths, but they do not create the same clash as seconds and sevenths.

Dissonant intervals

The most dissonant intervals lie a major or minor second apart from each other, though this is still a subjective perception. Some folk music from Hungary and Bulgaria, for example, uses seconds and sevenths, where we would expect to find thirds and fifths.

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$\triangle$ **Half step clashes**
Major seconds and minor sevenths don't clash with the same intensity as minor seconds and major sevenths, which are separated by a half step from the bass note, or octave.



SEE ALSO

◀ 56–59 Intervals

◀ 60–61 Major scales

◀ 70–71 The circle of fifths

Modern period

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REAL WORLD

Arnold Schoenberg

Arnold Schoenberg (1874–1951) was one of the several composers who, around the turn of the 19th and 20th centuries, sought to "emancipate" dissonance. His design of a 12 whole step row was not new, but he created a systematic practice that would influence musicians through the 20th century and beyond. He used it to make music of great beauty and passion, such as his string quartets, which evolved from his earlier "Expressionist" style of composition.



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$\triangleleft$ Added seventh

Here C major in root position has an added seventh of B. Despite the consonance of the triadic C-E-G below it, the added seventh makes the whole chord sound dissonant.